UNIT 11

WAVES

We are slowed down sound and light waves, a walking bundle of frequencies tuned into the cosmos. We are souls dressed up in sacred biochemical garments and our bodies are the instruments through which our souls play their music – Albert Einstein

Learning Objectives

In this unit, the student is exposed to

- waves and their types (transverse and longitudinal)
- basic terms like wavelength, frequency, time period and amplitude of a wave
- velocity of transverse waves and longitudinal waves
- velocity of sound waves
- reflection of sound waves from plane and curved surfaces and its applications
- progressive waves and their graphical representation
- superposition principle, interference of waves, beats and standing waves
- characteristics of stationary waves, sonometer
- fundamental frequency, harmonics and overtones
- intensity and loudness
- vibration of air column – closed organ pipe, open organ pipe and resonance air column
- Doppler effect and its applications

11.1 INTRODUCTION

In the previous chapter, we have discussed the oscillation of a particle. Consider a medium which consists of a collection of particles. If the disturbance is created at one end, it propagates and reaches the other end. That is, the disturbance produced at the first mass point is transmitted to the next neighbouring mass point, and so on. Notice that here, only the disturbance is transmitted, not the mass points. Similarly, the speech we deliver is due to the vibration of our vocal chord inside the throat. This leads to the vibration of the surrounding air molecules and hence, the effect of speech (information) is transmitted from one point in space to another point in space without the medium carrying the particles. Thus, *the disturbance which carries energy and momentum from one point in space to another point in space without the transfer of the medium is known as a* wave.



Figure 11.1 Standing waves in a violin

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